Cookpoint Academy
Executive Summary

Problem

Many immigrant families and teenagers in our city want to find work but do not know how to get started. The restaurant industry is one of the biggest employers of immigrants and young people, and it often has open positions. However, most restaurants require a food-handler certification, and many want some cooking experience. The people who most need these jobs often do not have access to affordable training. Community colleges can be far away, and their classes may be expensive or held at inconvenient times. Language barriers also make it hard to follow traditional cooking instruction. We believe there is a gap between the people who want to work in food service and the training that is available to them in their own neighborhoods.

Solution

Cookpoint Academy is a neighborhood teaching kitchen that uses connected smart stoves to guide students through cooking classes. Each stove has a screen that shows the student what to do next, including the right temperature, how long to cook, and how to handle the food safely. Because the stove guides the student, the class does not depend entirely on the instructor, and students can learn at their own pace. The guidance can be shown in several languages, which helps families who are still learning English. Students attend a series of classes that build skills step by step. At the end of the series, they prepare for the food-handler certification exam. After certification, we help connect students with restaurants that are hiring for entry level positions.

We believe this combination of hardware, curriculum and a local physical space is a new way to deliver job training. The teaching kitchen also becomes a place where the neighborhood can gather, which we think will help us build trust with families.

Market

The market for Cookpoint Academy is immigrant families and teenagers who are interested in working in restaurants. There are many immigrants in our metropolitan area, and a large share of them work in food service or want to. There are also many teenagers looking for their first job. If even a small percentage of these people enrolled in our classes, the market would be large. The restaurant industry is also growing and often reports difficulty finding workers, which suggests there is demand for trained employees. We have not yet conducted a formal market study, but we have talked informally with friends and family members who said the idea sounds interesting. We plan to do more research once we have funding.

Business Model

Cookpoint Academy will earn revenue in several ways. First, students or their families will pay a class fee for each series of classes. Second, we hope to receive payments from restaurants that hire our graduates, similar to a recruiting fee. Third, we may apply for grants from workforce development programs and foundations. Fourth, we may eventually sell or lease our smart stove system to other training programs and schools. We have not yet decided on exact prices. Because our target students may have limited income, we expect to keep class fees low, and we believe that grants and restaurant payments can make up the difference. The smart stoves are a significant cost, but we believe they will pay for themselves over time because they allow us to run more classes with fewer instructors.

Competition

Our competitors include community college culinary programs, nonprofit job training organizations, and online cooking videos and courses. Community colleges offer more advanced training but are often expensive and far from the neighborhoods we serve. Nonprofits offer

valuable programs, but many have long waiting lists and limited space. Online courses are cheap but do not give students hands-on practice or help with finding jobs. We believe Cookpoint Academy is different because we combine hands-on cooking with smart technology and job placement in one local place. We do not believe any other organization in our area offers exactly this combination. We recognize that larger organizations could copy our approach, but we think our local relationships will give us an advantage.

Team

Marisol Echeverria-Tran is our chief executive. She is a business major at our university and has worked part time in restaurants for three years. She leads strategy, partnerships and fundraising.

Dwayne Okonkwo-Hale is our chief technology officer. He is a computer engineering student who designed and built our prototype smart stove guidance system. He leads hardware and software development.

Priyanka Venkataraghavan is our head of programs. She is studying education and nutrition and is responsible for designing the class curriculum and preparing students for certification.

We do not yet have a professional chef on the team, but we plan to hire or partner with one. We also plan to recruit advisors from the restaurant industry and from workforce development organizations.

Milestones and Financials

So far we have defined our core business concept and formed a legal entity as an S Corp. Dwayne has built a first prototype of the smart stove guidance system, which displays steps and timers on a screen connected to a single stove. We have tested the prototype with a small group of friends, who said it was easy to use. We have not yet run a real class, signed up any students, or partnered with any restaurants. We do not yet have a website.

Our financial plan is still early. We estimate that opening our first teaching kitchen will require a space to rent, several smart stoves, kitchen equipment, insurance, and money to pay instructors. We believe the total startup cost will be significant, though we have not yet prepared a detailed budget. We do not currently have revenue. We have personally contributed a small amount of money to form the company and build the prototype. Over the next two years, we hope to open one kitchen, enroll a few hundred students, and reach break-even, although we have not yet built a projection to show how this will happen.

What We Are Asking For

We are asking for prize funding from this competition to help us rent a space and buy the first set of smart stoves and kitchen equipment. We would also welcome mentorship from judges and advisors with experience in restaurants, education, and hardware. In particular, we would like help with building a detailed budget, understanding food safety regulations, and finding restaurants willing to hire our graduates. We would also appreciate introductions to local community organizations and grant programs. We believe that with the support of this competition, Cookpoint Academy can begin to help immigrant families and teenagers build careers in food service, while building a company that grows over time.